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Review

Immiscibility-driven folding: A new design strategy to control polymer chain conformation and morphology

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Dedicated to Professor Nikos Hadjichristidis on his 80th birthday, and to our long-lasting and cherished friendship.

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Chain conformation
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ABSTRACT

Controlling chain conformation is a challenge that has drawn the attention of researchers for several decades; achieving control in solution is inspired by the remarkably elegant strategies seen in biological macromolecules, like proteins, RNA, DNA etc. On the other hand, controlling the chain conformation of polymers in the solid state is a more difficult task, but it is one that could have important ramifications, especially to elicit interesting properties that require distances between different function-imparting units to be precisely controlled. Most of the strategies examined for conformational control utilize *intra-chain noncovalent interactions*, such as H-bonding, π-stacking, charge-transfer, metal-ion coordination, etc. During the past decade, we have explored an alternate approach, wherein suitably designed periodically grafted amphiphilic polymers (PGAP) carrying long alkylene backbone segments and pendant PEG segments, were shown to adopt a folded zigzag conformation so as to collocate the alkylene segments at the center with PEG segments on either side; the crystallization of the central alkylene segments stabilize the folded conformation and leads to lamellar morphologies with fine tunable layer dimensions. This strategy was more recently exploited to precisely locate functional units, such as mesogens, within layered morphologies at well-defined distances in bulk samples. In this short perspective article, we shall discuss the genesis and design of periodically grafted amphiphilic polymers, and illustrate its utility to generate functional polymeric materials, wherein specific units are located at well-orchestrated distances in the bulk polymer; thus, revealing the power of design at the molecular level to impact properties in the bulk.

1. Introduction

Long chain polymers typically adopt random coil conformations owing to their significantly higher configurational entropy. Coercing polymers to adopt one specific conformation is a challenge that has beckoned researchers for several decades [1]; one of the main inspirations comes from the exquisite secondary and tertiary structures adopted by proteins, which is at the core of the observed selectivity and speed of enzymatic catalysis. In enzymes, the entropic costs are overcome by the intra-chain H-bonding interactions that provide the enthalpic stabilization to the folded structure; in addition, several other factors, such as solvophobic exclusion of hydrophobic amino acid residues, π-stacking interactions, intra-chain disulfide bonds, etc., contribute to further stabilization of the folded form. In synthetic polymers two distinct strategies have been explored to control their solution conformation: one is to restrict the degrees of conformational freedom of the chain either by the choice of repeat unit structure and/or by the use of H-bonding between adjacent repeat units to coerce a preferred conformation. These approaches have been very extensively studied and numerous examples for stabilizing specific conformations [2–5], such as a helix, have been reported; a few examples of these are shown in Fig. 1.

The second approach utilizes a combination of multiple weak intra-chain interactions between *non-adjacent units along the chain* to stabilize the desired conformation; one of the earliest examples of this strategy was described by Iverson [6,7], who utilized charge-transfer interaction between electron-rich and electron-deficient aromatic units located in an alternating manner, aided by periodic amphiphilicity, as depicted in Fig. 2. Although, this example described the folding only in well-defined oligomers, it revealed the potential of using a combination of other types of weak intra-chain interactions to stabilize a chosen folded conformation. Following this, we demonstrated the use of a combination of weak intra-chain interactions for the folding of a truly flexible synthetic polymer chain [8,9]; the design entailed an alternating placement of electron-rich (D) and electron-deficient (A) aromatic units linked via flexible oligooxyethylene segments, as shown in Fig. 2. The folding in solution was induced by the presence of alkali-metal ions, which

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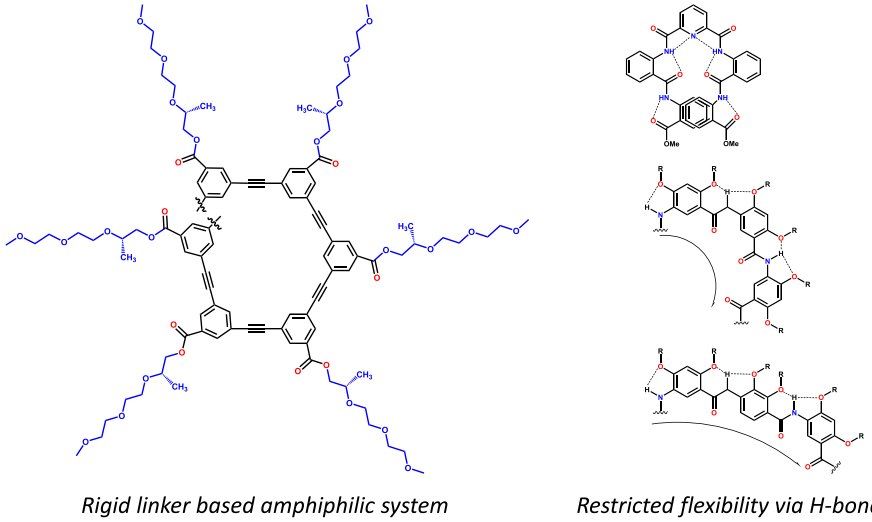

Fig. 1. Some examples of strategies for conformational control in synthetic polymers.

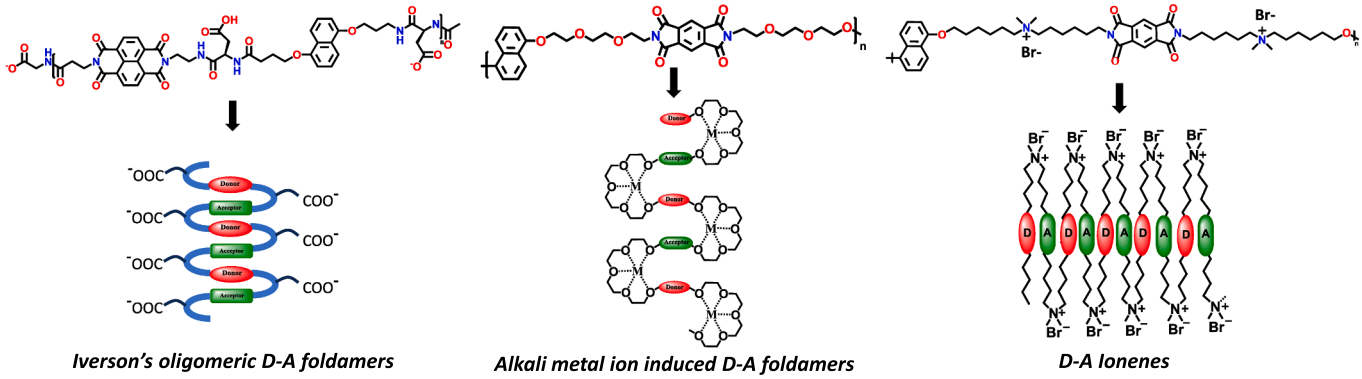

Fig. 2. Charge-transfer assisted folding of oligomers and polymers; coordination with the alkali metal ion in the second example brings the D and A units in proximity to promote C-T interaction, likewise the hydrophobicity-driven collocation in the case of ionenes promotes C-T stabilization.

coordinate with the oxyethylene segment to bring the D and A units in proximity so as to induce charge-transfer (CT) interaction, and thereby stabilize the folded form; an interesting feature of this approach is that a color change of the solution reflected the formation of the folded conformation. This strategy of utilizing CT interactions was also extended to demonstrating that an electron-rich aromatic folding agent can reversibly fold an acceptor-bearing polymer chain via a two-point interaction [10,11]. Later, we also showed that ionenes carrying donor and acceptor units, located within alternate alkylene segments (Fig. 2), also exhibited strong folding propensities that were maximum in polar solvents, like water [12].

Kunitake et al., had earlier suggested that simple symmetric ionenes would adopt a folded zigzag conformation in water to minimize the exposure of the long hydrophobic alkylene segments, especially when the alkylene segment length exceeds a critical value (C12) [13,14]; this prompted us to ask the question: *would replacing the ionic groups with water-soluble pendant segments, like PEG, also lead to the zigzag folding of polymer chains?* To address this, we prepared the first periodically grafted amphiphilic copolymer (PGAC) [15], wherein polyesters carrying long alkylene segments are interjected by pendant PEG segments at periodic intervals, as depicted in Fig. 3.

Two polymers, one carrying a C12 alkylene segment in the backbone and the other a C22 segment were prepared; both these polymers carried the same length of PEG segments (hexaethylene glycol monomethyl ether) at periodic intervals. It was observed that the polymer carrying the longer C22 alkylene segment underwent the anticipate zigzag folding to collocate the alkylene segment in the center and the PEG segments on either side; importantly, in the solid state, a lamellar morphology was formed with the *d*-spacing consistent with the height of the folded chain (Fig. 3). Furthermore, DSC studies revealed a peak at ~ 60 °C, reflecting melting of the crystalline domains formed by the backbone alkylene segment; crystallization apparently also drives the microphase separation and layering of the alkylene and PEG segments. One of the drawbacks of this approach, of condensing a PEGylated malonate monomer with diols, was its broader adaptability; hence, an alternate approach wherein desired segments can be installed at periodic intervals, in a post-polymerization step, was designed.

1.1. Periodically clickable polymers

Cu-catalyzed alkyne-azide click (CuAAC) reaction is a remarkably useful tool for quantitative installation of desired segments under mild reaction conditions [16,17], which has been extensively used for a variety of applications in biology [18]; the 2022 chemistry Nobel Prize is a testament to importance of this discovery and subsequent elaborations that further improved its utility. Thus, design of polymers wherein "clickable" units are periodically located along their backbone would be an important step that will help expand the scope of periodically grafted polymers.

In our first study, we condensed a propargylated diol, namely 2-propargyl 1,3-propanediol, with the acid chloride of 1,20-icosanedioic acid (C20) to yield the desired periodically clickable polyester [19]. Clicking the propargyl groups with a fluoroalkyl azide generated a polymer bearing alkylene backbone segments with periodically located

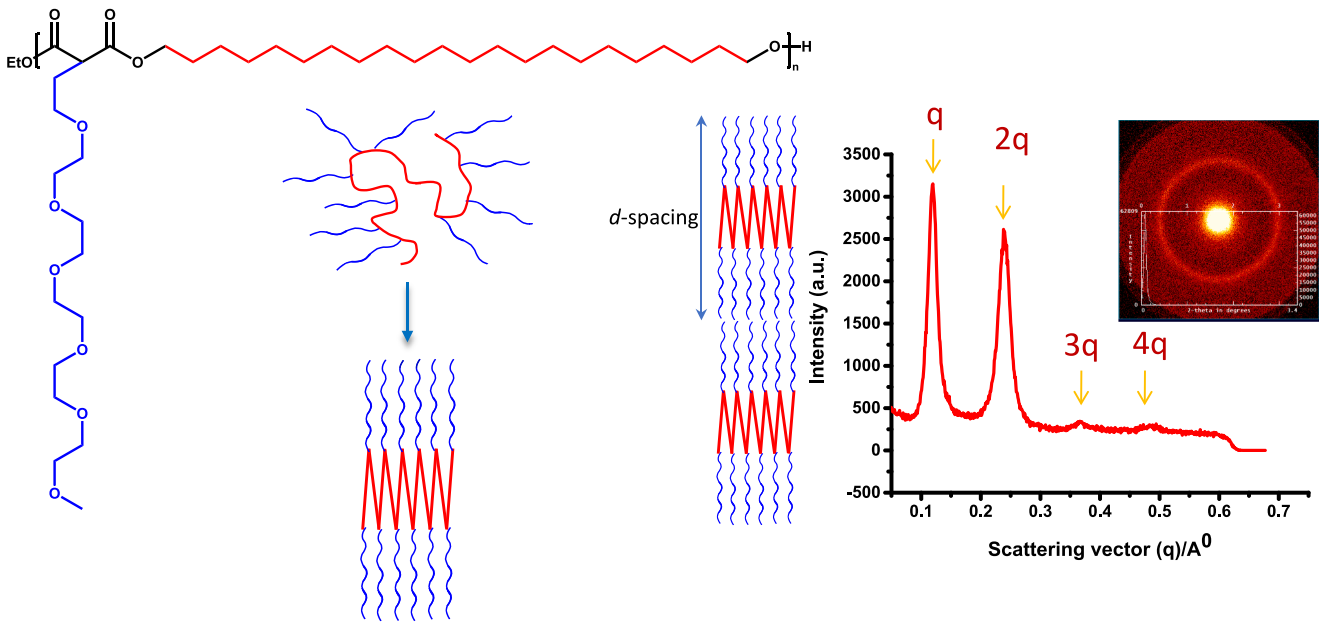

Fig. 3. Periodically grafted amphiphilic polyesters prepared by melt transesterification of PEGylated malonate monomers with docosane (C22) diol; zigzag folding segregates the alkylene and PEG segments and leads to a lamellar morphology, as evident from the SAXS profile, shown in the plot [15].

fluoroalkyl pendant units; as earlier, the immiscibility between the alkyl and fluoroalkyl groups drove the zigzag folding of the chain causing the collocation of the alkyl and the fluoroalkyl segments within alternate layers. In this case, the DSC thermogram exhibited two distinct melting transitions (Fig. 4), thus providing the first evidence of independent crystallization of the backbone alkylene (HC) and pendant fluorocarbon (FC) segments, caused due to the zigzag folding of the chain. An interesting and unique observation in these periodically grafted polymers is that they exhibited a fluid birefringent phase at temperatures in between the two melting peaks, suggesting the formation of liquid crystalline mesophase, even in the absence of traditional rigid aromatic mesogens. While the SAXS studies yielded the lamellar spacing, the WAXS profiles clearly revealed the formation of both a paraffinic hydrocarbon (HC) lattice with an interchain distance of 0.42 nm, and a fluorocarbon (FC) lattice with an interchain distance of 0.5 nm [19].

1.2. Controlling the lamellar dimensions in PGAPs

Having demonstrated that periodically grafted amphiphilic copolymers exhibited a strong tendency to fold in a zigzag manner to generate a lamellar morphology with the backbone and pendant segments occupying alternate layers, an interesting challenge would be to control the lamellar dimensions by varying the polymer structure; in other words, controlling a macroscopic (bulk) feature by a molecular-level structural variation. To accomplish this, we adopted an alternate strategy using a bio-sourced monomer to prepare PGAPs; dibutyl itaconate was condensed with a long-chain alkane diol, under melt-transesterification polymerization, to yield a polyester carrying periodically located *exo*-chain double bonds of the itaconate unit (Fig. 5). The itaconate double bonds are susceptible to Michael addition reactions and hence either an amine or a thiol can be readily added to it, providing an alternate approach to install desired segments at periodic intervals [20]; the periodicity along the backbone is in turn governed by the length of the α,ω-alkanediol used during the polymerization.

Using 1,20-icosane diol, a periodically clickable polyester, namely poly(icosylene itaconate), was prepared; PEG monomethyl ether thiols (PEG-SH) of different molecular weights, namely trioxyethylene, PEG350, PEG550 and PEG750, were reacted with the parent polyester to yield a series of PGAPs where the periodicity is fixed but the length of the pendant PEG segments was varied, as depicted in Fig. 5. DSC thermograms revealed several interesting features; firstly, all the polymers showed an endothermic peak at ~ 45 °C, which was ascribed to the melting of backbone alkylene segments. A second peak was seen at a lower temperature, in the case of polymers carrying PEG550 and

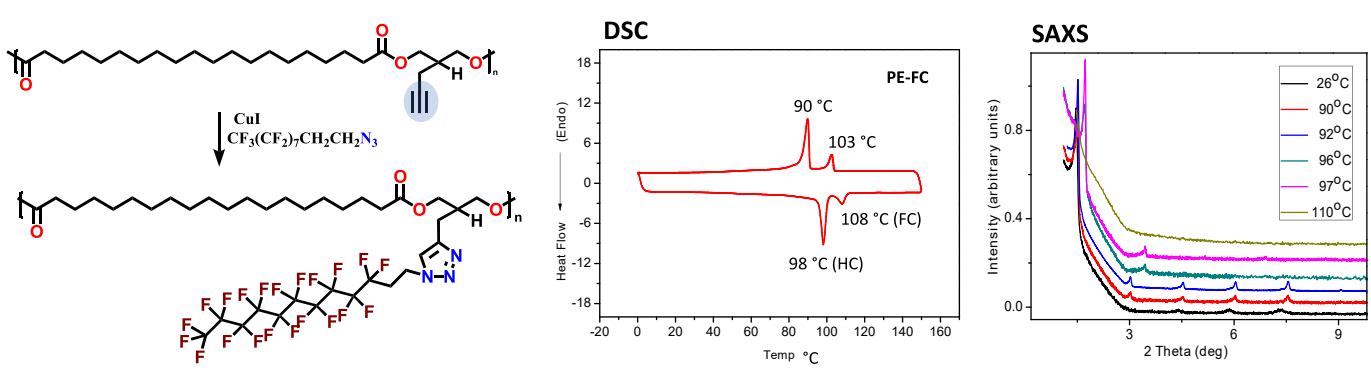

Fig. 4. The periodically clickable polyester, upon clicking with fluorocarbon (FC) azide, generates a hydrocarbon (HC)-rich backbone with FC pendant segments, which undergoes zigzag folding leading to the alternate layering of the HC and FC segments. Consequently, the DSC curve exhibits two melting transitions and SAXS reveals a lamellar morphology [19].

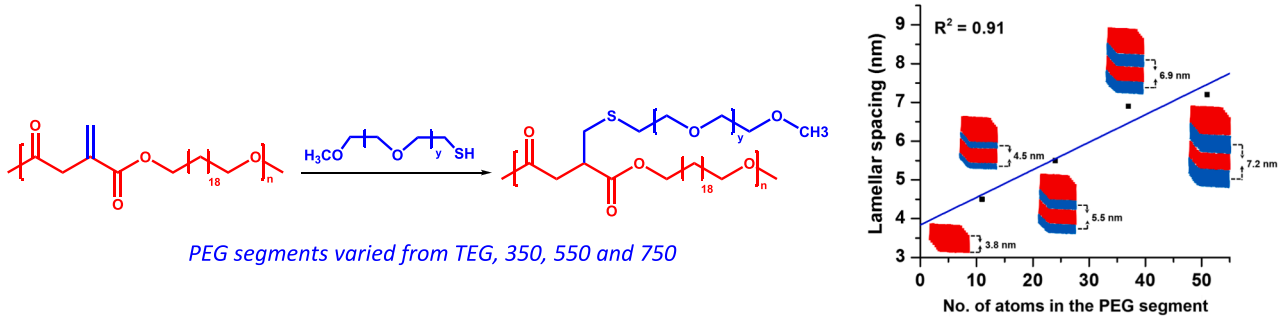

Fig. 5. Properties of PGAPs based on poly(icosylene itaconate) bearing pendant PEG segments of varying size. The plot depicts the variation of lamellar dimension with increase in the pendant PEG segment length, revealing the precise control that is exercised [20].

PEG750 segments; this was ascribed to the melting of the PEG segment, as it showed the expected increase in value with the length of the PEG segment [20]. As earlier, here too collocation and independent crystallization of both the backbone and pendant segments were observed; furthermore, SAXS profiles showed the formation of a well-ordered lamellar morphology and the *d*-spacing was seen to increase with the size of the pendant PEG segment, as seen in the plot in Fig. 5. Interestingly, the *d*-spacing varied linearly with the size of the pendant PEG segment, permitting an extrapolation to estimate the size of the folded alkylene segment alone; this value matched well with the expected value considering an all-*trans* extended conformation for the alkylene segment. Here too, the room-temperature WAXS profiles helped confirm the formation of a crystalline paraffinic lattice by the backbone alkylene segments; in addition, an amorphous halo was seen, whose relative contribution increased, as expected, with the size of the pendant PEG segment.

Similarly, the lamellar size can also be fine-tuned by varying the periodicity of the grafting. For this, we exploited an interesting observation, previously made by Menges et al., that ester units are reasonably well tolerated within crystalline paraffinic lattices [21]; hence, specifically designed diol monomers carrying long alkylene segments, along with a centrally located clickable propargyl unit, was condensed with diacid chlorides of different lengths, which in turn increased the distance between the adjacent clickable units. CuAAC reaction with PEG550-azide was used to install PEG segments at periodic intervals. As seen earlier, the SAXS profiles revealed the formation of a lamellar morphology and the *d*-spacing increased linearly with the number of methylene units in the diacid chloride, as shown in Fig. 6; the slope (0.127 nm per methylene) of the variation matched exactly with the value expected for an extended all-*trans* configuration of the alkylene segment [22].

As evident from the foregone discussions, periodically grafted amphiphilic polymers provide an interesting strategy to generate lamellar morphology with fine control over the dimension of the lamellae attained via the zigzag folding of the polymer backbone.

1.3. PGPs carrying mesogenic units

Having established a design strategy to fold periodically grafted polymers (PGPs) and generate well-defined lamellar morphologies, an interesting and potentially useful step forward is to install specific functional units either within the backbone or in the pendant segment. We selected two mesogenic units, namely biphenyl and azobenzene, for incorporation into PGPs; further, these were located at the center of either the backbone or pendant segments, so that the folding and interdigitation will result in the precise layering of the mesogens, as depicted in Fig. 7. Thus, suitably derivatized malonate diesters and diols carrying mesogenic units were designed and polymers carrying the mesogenic units either in the backbone or pendant segment were prepared.

It was observed that, both when the mesogens are located at the center of the backbone segment or when present in the pendant segment, zigzag folding occurs causing the anticipated layering of the mesogens in the solid state; this in turn causes several of the polymers to exhibit a

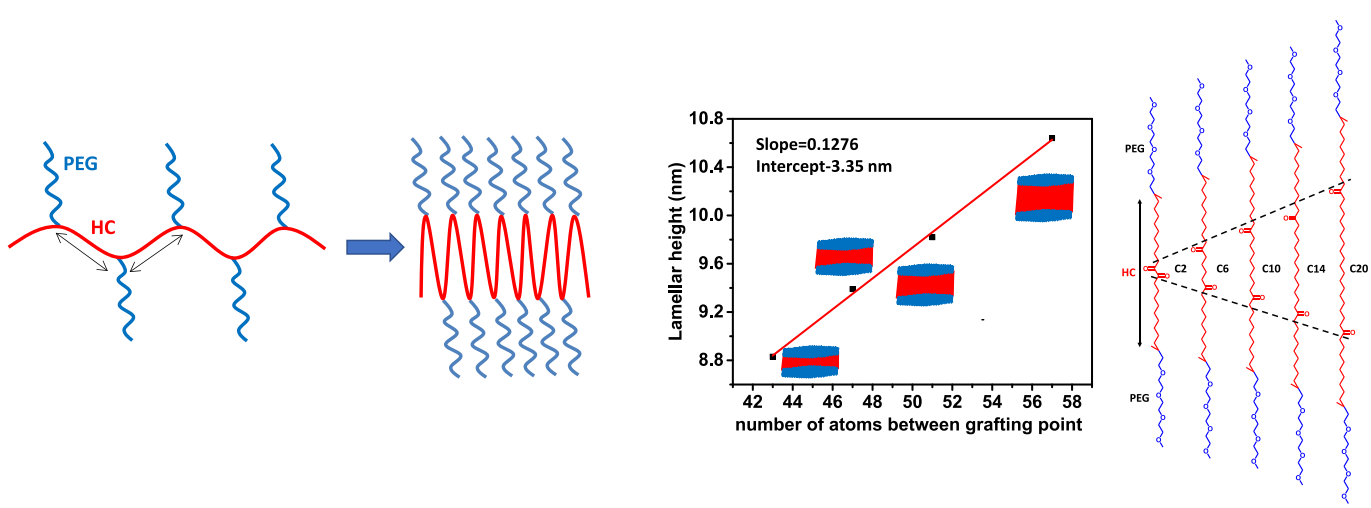

Fig. 6. Variation of lamellar dimension with periodicity of grafting in PGACs. Here the backbone HC segment (shown in red) length is varied, and the lamellar domain size is shown to increase with the backbone HC segment length [22]. (For interpretation of the references to color in this figure legend, the reader is referred to the web version of this article.)

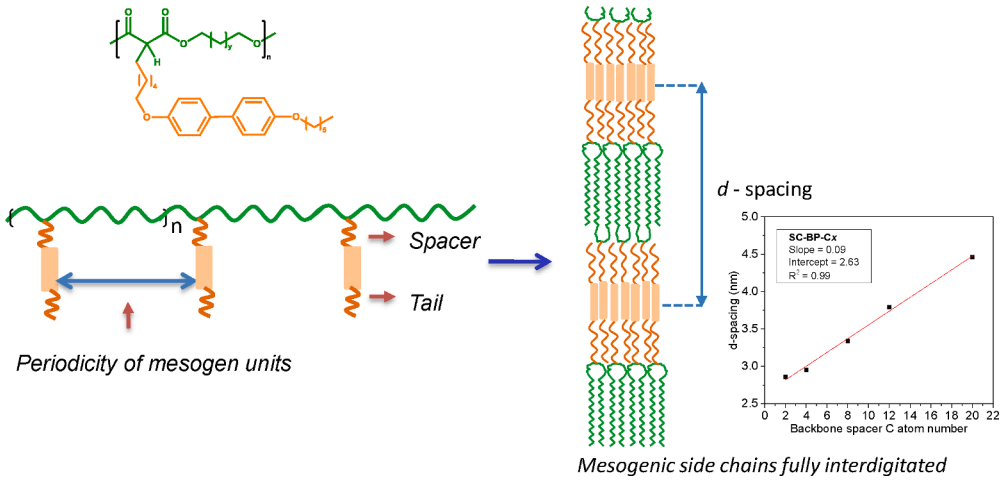

Fig. 7. Periodically grafted side-chain liquid crystalline polyesters; here, folding of the chain leads to layering of the biphenyl mesogens, wherein the interlayer spacing is governed by the backbone and the spacer segment lengths; the tail segments help fully fill the volume within the interdigitated layers [23].

smectic type mesophase [23,24].

In an effort to elaborate this strategy further, we prepared polymers carrying two different mesogens, one in the backbone and the other in the side-chain [25]; segregated layering of the two mesogens was shown to occur, which was reflected in the inter-lamellar spacing retrieved from the SAXS profiles. The *d*-spacing in these polymers were roughly half of that observed when mesogens were present in either the backbone or pendant segment; this was because the X-ray scattering measurement is unable to differentiate between the biphenyl and azobenzene layers because of their similar scattering cross-sections, thereby reducing the spacing to nearly half the value, as depicted in Fig. 8. Thus, the periodic placement of functional units in a suitably designed polymer provides an interesting strategy to control the bulk ordering of these units.

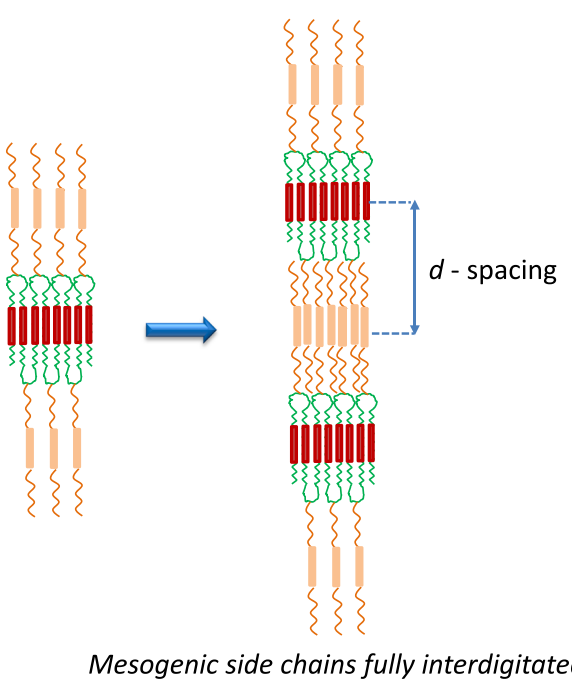

Fig. 8. PGPs carrying two different mesogens, one in the backbone and the other in pendant segment, leads to layering of the two mesogens within discrete layers, at controlled distances [25].

1.4. Desymmetrized PGAPs

Most of the strategies described thus far generate symmetric folded chains; in other words, the segments on either side of the folded chain are the same. An interesting challenge would be to develop an approach to desymmetrize the folded chain, such that different segments are present on each side. To do so, we prepared periodically clickable polymer bearing two orthogonally clickable units located in an alternating fashion along the polymer backbone, as depicted in Fig. 9; selective, sequential clicking of the propargyl groups with fluoroalkyl azide, followed by thia-Michael addition of PEG-SH to the itaconate units, generated a polymer carrying fluoroalkyl and PEG segments, installed in an alternating manner [26]. The zigzag folding of this chain will yield a polymer carrying PEG on one side and fluoroalkyl segment on the other: thereby generating a *Janus*-type folded chain, as shown in Fig. 9.

DSC and X-ray scattering studies clearly revealed the formation of three distinct layered domains exhibiting independent crystallization; in this case, the *d*-spacing estimated from SAXS profiles was almost twice that typically seen in the symmetric systems with similar alkyl/PEG lengths. This observation suggests that a bilayer ordering of the folded Janus chains has occurred and the lamellar spacing reflects the average distance between the FC layers in such an arrangement (Fig. 9); the FC domain possessing higher X-ray scattering cross-section dominates the scattering profile leading to this observation. This bilayer lamellar ordering is reminiscent of the morphology seen in ABC type triblock copolymers [27].

1.5. Examining folding of PGAPs in solution

To probe the folding in solution, we extended the approach used for generating unsymmetric folded chains, because of the potential of such folded chains to cause directional ordering of chromophoric dipoles in solution, as depicted in Fig. 10. Second harmonic light scattering (SHLS) is an interesting technique that permits the probing of correlated chromophore ordering that occurs at small scales [28]; we had earlier used this technique to estimate critical micelle concentrations of chromophore-bearing surfactants [29].

The designed polymers are periodically amphiphilic bearing pendant PEG segments, wherein only every alternate segment carries a dipolar unit embedded within [30]; thus, upon going from a good solvent, like chloroform, to a segment-selective polar solvent, like methanol, the chain would be expected to fold in a zigzag fashion to minimize exposure of the central HC segments. This in turn will lead to the directional ordering of the dipoles; the plot of the SHLS signal clearly reveals a

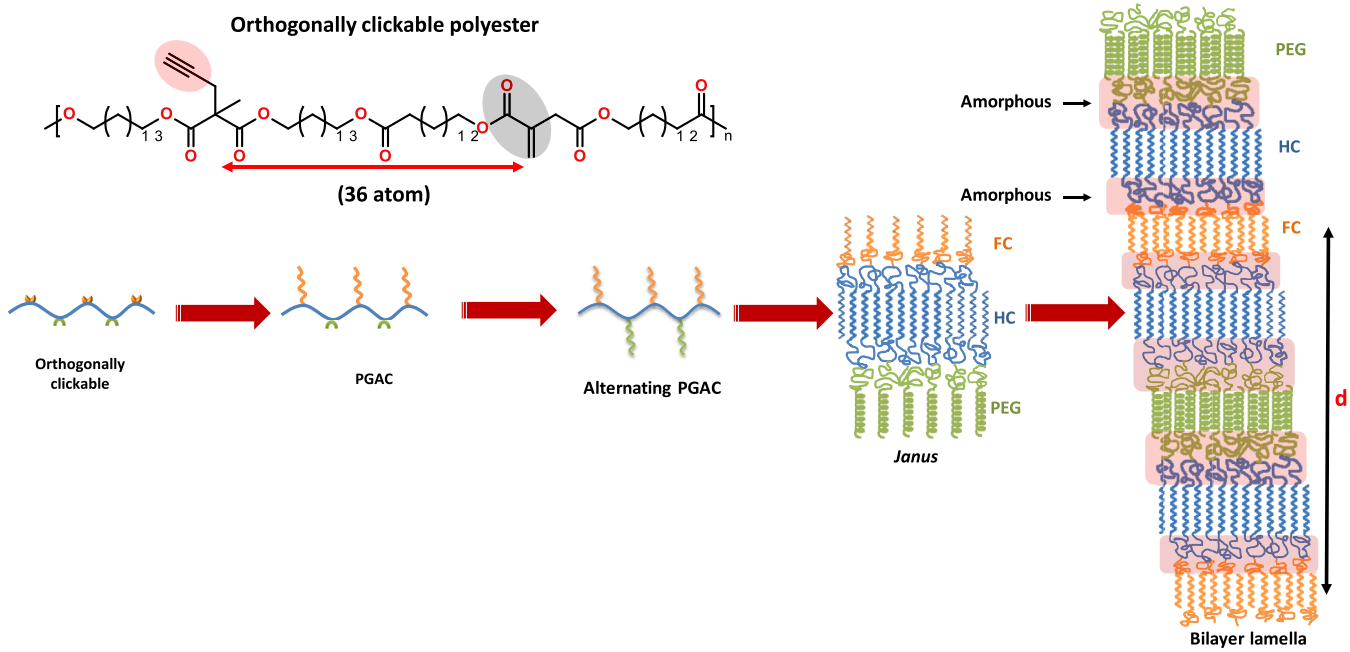

Fig. 9. Periodically grafted polymers carrying two different segments on either side of the folded chain was prepared using a precursor bearing two alternatingly located orthogonally clickable groups, namely itaconate and propargyl. SAXS profiles reveal the spacing between adjacent FC layers, which is due to their higher X-ray scattering cross-section [26] .

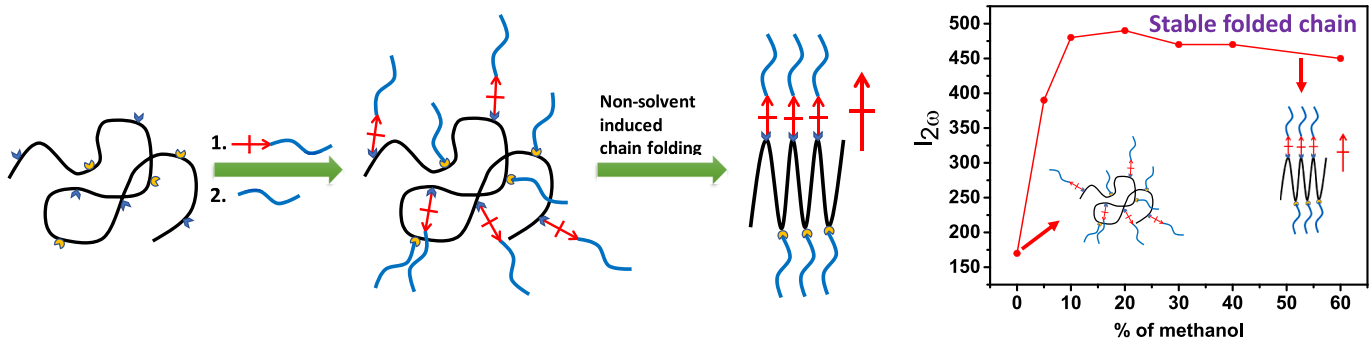

Fig. 10. Periodically amphiphilic polymers carrying PEG segments with a dipolar unit present only in every alternate segment, upon folding, causes the directional orientation of chromophores. The plot shows the increase in the intensity of second harmonic scattered light (SHLS) upon chain folding, which was induced by increasing amount of methanol, and is ascribed to the directional ordering of chromophores [30].

substantial increase in the signal intensity beyond a critical volume-fraction of methanol, after which it remained roughly constant. The volume-fraction at which this levels-off can be taken as the point at which the zigzag folding and dipole ordering has occurred; beyond which little change in the conformation occurs.

More recently, we began exploring the possibility of cross-stitching folded chains by the inclusion of photo-dimerizable units, instead of mesogens, within the backbone segments of PGAPs; here di-cinnamoyl ester (DCE) units were incorporated centrally within the backbone segments and pendant PEG segments of different lengths were clicked on to the polymer (Fig. 11).

Zigzag folding of the polymer chain occurs in water, which selectively solvates only the PEG segments, and this brings the DCE units in close proximity to permit photo-dimerization; it was revealed that the photo-reaction causes the crosslinking of the folded chains to yield single-chain crosslinked nanoparticles (SCNPs). Our studies revealed that SCNPs can be generated at much higher solution concentrations than earlier possible, provided the pendant PEG segments are long enough to preclude inter-chain interactions [31].

2. Summary and outlook

The study of periodically grafted amphiphilic polymers (PGAPs) has revealed an interesting design strategy to control polymer chain conformation and translate the folding propensity to generate lamellar morphologies in the bulk state. Although our early designs utilized chemically distinct backbone and pendant segments, like long chain alkylene and PEG, it has become clear that strong differences in solubility parameters between the segments are not essential for the zigzag folding to occur. This was also shown by several pioneering studies by Wagener and coworkers using ADMET to access periodically substituted polyethylenes [32]; they showed that, if the substituents are large and do not pack effectively within the crystalline paraffinic lattice, chain folding occurs and consequently the pendant units get located on either side of the folded lamellae. When ionic groups are periodically located as pendant units on polyethylene or polyethylene-like polyesters, it results in their collocation and layering, which has been exploited for developing proton/ion conducting solid polymer electrolytes [33,34], thereby revealing their potential utility. Differences in packing constraints between the backbone and pendant segments, especially when both these are long, also appear to induce chain folding; this was evident

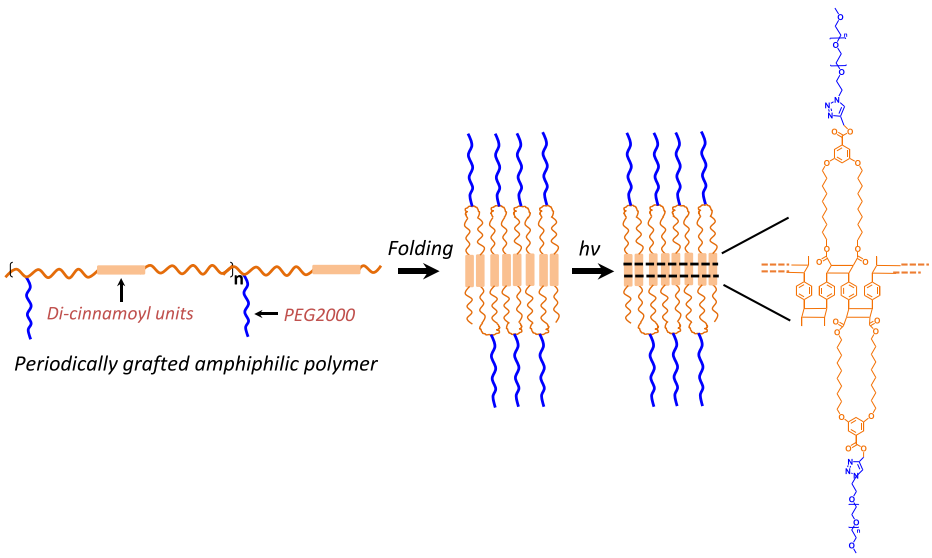

Fig. 11. Cross-stitching of folded PGAPs to generate single-chain nanoparticles. Installation of dicinnamoyl units centrally within the backbone of PGAPs permits the photodimerization of the dicinnamoyl units, when the chains adopt a folded conformation.

in several of our studies wherein mesogens were installed either in the backbone or within the pendant segment, causing the mesogenic units to become confined with a layer. We also showed that if two different mesogens are installed in the backbone and pendant segment, segregated layered ordering is generated; this observation holds the potential of locating different types of functional units, such as electron-rich and electron-deficient aromatic units, within segregated layers by suitable design of the polymer structure. It would allow one to examine energy and electron transfer processes in polymers at precisely controlled distances. Other studies have shown that inclusion of H-bonding segments within the hydrophobic alkylene segment helps stabilize the folded structure [35,36], further revealing many more exciting possibilities for elaboration. A very recent study also demonstrated that significantly smaller backbone segments can also lead to folded structures with smaller lamellar dimensions [37]; in this case, it appears that the presence of –OH groups around the chain-fold may have helped stabilize the lamellar morphology.

One important outcome of the folding-induced microphase separation is the very small domain sizes attainable. In amorphous block copolymers, microphase separation does not occur below a critical χN (segregation strength) value, and hence, the only way to reduce the domain size is to increase the χ value, so that microphase separation can occur at smaller values of N. This strategy has been extensively explored by increasing the hydrophilic nature of one of the blocks [38–43]; however, this evidently requires modifying the block composition. The use of periodically grafted polymers, on the other hand, utilizes the topology of the connectivity between the two segments and therefore overcomes the lower segregation strength limitation; in many instances, however, it is important to recognize that crystallization of one of the segments drives the formation of the lamellar morphology. In essence, the PGAP approach provides an alternate strategy to generate lamellar morphologies at significantly smaller length scales than typically accessible using block copolymer approaches. Furthermore, it also permits incorporation of other functional units within the backbone and pendant segments, and consequently precise control over distances between different functional units can be achieved, which is not easily possible using other approaches.

Although PGAPs have been primarily studied in the solid state, examining the folding in solution is an interesting challenge that needs further investigation. We showed that by designing periodically clickable polymers carrying two different orthogonally clickable units placed in an alternating manner, we can generate *Janus* folded chains carrying different segments on either side. The generation of *Janus* folded structures using orthogonally clickable polymers also provides an interesting opportunity to order chromophoric dipoles along the same direction; we showed using second-harmonic light scattering that the zigzag folding of the polymer leads to an enhanced SHLS signal, reflecting the directional ordering of the dipoles. Translating this to the solid state to achieve directional ordering of chromophores in films is an interesting challenge that is worthy of further investigation; clearly this would require inclusion of additional specific interactions that lead to a directional arrangement of the folded chains in the layered structure.

Cross-stitching of folded chains in solution presents yet another opportunity; several studies have examined intra-chain crosslinking to generate single-chain nanoparticles (SCNPs), wherein the conformation of the chain is mostly unregulated, and therefore the crosslinking must be carried out under very dilute conditions to prevent inter-chain crosslinking. However, we have seen that when PGAPs, bearing photoreactive units within the zigzag folded backbone segment, are encased by long pendant PEG chains, SCNPs can be prepared by photolysis at substantially higher concentrations (~100 times) than typically reported in the literature [44]. This would be a significant advantage for scale-up, as and when exciting applications of SCNPs begin mushrooming. Other approaches to the synthesis of SCNPs at higher concentrations, while precluding multichain aggregate formation, have utilized slow addition [45] and core-appended photoreactive units [46,47]; both of which have also been able to prepare SCNPs at significantly higher concentrations.

In summary, this perspective highlights a new design strategy to regulate the folding of polymer chains; controlled chain folding can be used to coerce the formation of a lamellar morphology in the solid state, especially when either backbone and/or pendant segments exhibit a strong propensity to crystallize. We believe that this strategy can be extended to develop a variety of interesting polymeric systems, wherein ordering and precise control of distances between functional entities are essential. Folded chains in solutions present other interesting possibilities, such as development of core–shell type single-chain nanoparticle, inclusion of function-imparting moieties into core–shell SCNPs, etc.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Vidyalakshmi Damodara: Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing, Investigation. **Harshita Sardana:** Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing, Investigation. **S. Ramakrishnan:** Writing –

original draft, Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare the following financial interests/personal relationships which may be considered as potential competing interests: S Ramakrishnan reports financial support was provided by India Ministry of Science & Technology Department of Science and Technology. S Ramakrishnan reports financial support and administrative support were provided by Indian Institute of Science. If there are other authors, they declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data availability

No data was used for the research described in the article.

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